(Link: www.nhs.uk/)

# Migraine

Migraine is a condition that causes symptoms such as a severe headache, feeling sick and sensitivity to light. There is treatment to help manage symptoms.

## Symptoms of migraine

Migraine is a condition that causes a set of symptoms known as a migraine attack.

The main symptoms of a migraine attack are:

- a throbbing headache – this can be severe, often on 1 side of the head and can be worse when you move around
- feeling or being sick (nausea and vomiting)
- being very sensitive to light and sounds

You may also get symptoms at the start of a migraine attack, such as:

- feeling very tired and yawning a lot
- craving certain foods or feeling thirsty
- changes in your mood
- a stiff neck
- peeing more

Some people get warning signs that they're about to have a migraine attack (called aura), such as:

- problems with your sight, such as seeing zigzag lines or flashing lights
- numbness or a tingling that feels like pins and needles
- feeling dizzy
- difficulty speaking

Aura symptoms should not last for longer than 1 hour.

Migraine attacks usually last between 4 hours and 3 days, with early symptoms (such as feeling very tired) starting hours or up to 2 days before the head pain starts and finishing after the headache stops.

Some people have migraine attacks several times a week, while others do not have them as often.

Migraine attacks that happen just before or during your period are called menstrual migraines. They are often longer and more severe than migraine attacks at other times.

Most people find their migraine attacks slowly get better as they get older.

In women, migraine often gets better after the menopause and sometimes improves in pregnancy.

## Find out more

- The Migraine Trust: what is migraine? (Link: https://migrainetrust.org/understand-migraine/what-is-migraine/)
- The Migraine Trust: stages of a migraine attack (Link: https://migrainetrust.org/understand-migraine/stages-of-a-migraine-attack/)
- The Migraine Trust: types of migraine (Link: https://migrainetrust.org/understand-migraine/types-of-migraine/)

## See a GP if:

- your migraine attacks are severe or getting worse, or lasting longer than usual
- you have migraine attacks more than once a week
- you're finding it difficult to control your migraine
- you regularly get migraine before or during your period

## Ask for an urgent GP appointment or get help from NHS 111 if:

You have a migraine attack and:

- it's lasted longer than 72 hours
- aura symptoms last longer than 1 hour at a time
- you're pregnant or just had a baby

You can call 111 or get help from 111 online (Link: https://111.nhs.uk/triage/check-your-symptoms).

### Call 999 if you or your child:

- have a headache that came on suddenly and is extremely painful
- have problems speaking or remembering things
- lose your vision, or have blurred or double vision
- feel drowsy or confused
- have a seizure or fit
- have a very high temperature and symptoms of meningitis (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/meningitis/)
- cannot move or have weakness in the arms or legs on 1 side of your body, or 1 side of your face
- have recently had a head injury

Do not drive yourself to A&E.

The person you speak to at 999 will give you advice about what to do.

# Treatment for migraine

Migraine cannot be cured, but treatment can help:

- manage symptoms of a migraine attack
- prevent migraines attacks

The treatments available will depend on how severe your migraine is and how often you get migraine attacks.

You may have to try a combination of treatments before you find something that works for you.

Treatment for symptoms of a migraine attack includes:

- painkillers, such as ibuprofen and paracetamol
- medicines called triptans and gepants
- medicines that stop you feeling sick or being sick

If you're taking painkillers, take them as soon as your headache starts.

Treatment to prevent migraine attacks includes:

- medicines that help prevent migraine attacks, such as beta blockers, antidepressants and medicines for epilepsy
- acupuncture
- relaxation techniques and cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT)
- vitamin B2

A GP may also recommend making changes to your lifestyle to help manage migraine, such as eating at regular times and drinking less caffeine.

If none of these treatments help your symptoms, or they're getting worse, you may be referred to a specialist for further tests and treatment.

### Important

Try not to take painkillers for more than 2 days a week as this can cause you to get more headaches and make migraine harder to treat.

### Find out more

- The Migraine Trust: treatment options (Link: https://migrainetrust.org/live-with-migraine/healthcare/treatments/)
- The Migraine Trust: migraine in pregnancy (Link: https://migrainetrust.org/live-with-migraine/migraine-in-pregnancy/)

# Causes of migraine

It's not known what causes migraine, but it happens when there are changes to nerves and blood vessels in the brain.

You're more likely to get it if you have a close family member who has it.

Women are also more likely to get migraine than men.

Some people find certain triggers can cause migraine attacks, such as:

- having your period
- anxiety and depression
- stress and tiredness
- skipping meals or not eating regularly

- too much caffeine
- not getting enough regular exercise

It can help to keep a migraine diary to help you work out what might trigger your migraine attacks.

### Find out more

The Migraine Trust: keeping a headache diary (Link: https://migrainetrust.org/live-with-migraine/self-management/keeping-a-migraine-diary/)

## Things you can do to ease or reduce migraine

There are things you can do yourself to manage migraine, with help and advice from a GP.

### Do

- ✓ try sleeping or lying down in a darkened room during a migraine attack
- ✓ try to avoid things you know trigger your migraine attacks
- ✓ stay well hydrated, and limit how much caffeine and alcohol you drink
- ✓ try to keep to a healthy weight
- ✓ eat meals at regular times
- ✓ get regular exercise
- ✓ get plenty of sleep
- ✓ try to manage your stress

### Find out more

- The Migraine Trust: living with migraine (Link: https://migrainetrust.org/live-with-migraine/)

# Video: Migraine

Migraines affect 10 million people in the UK. Identifying and avoiding the things that trigger migraines is an important part of managing them, says Dr Dawn Harper.



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